



You may find it relaxing to have your feet massaged in the early stages of labor, even if you don't want your back or shoulders touched. A massage helps to relieve tension.

FINAL PREPARATIONS

It's amazing that even after 40 weeks of pregnancy, when labor begins, there is still a scramble before heading off to the hospital. So to avoid last-minute panic:

- **Make sure your bag is packed** (see [Items for your hospital bag](#)). You may also want have a list handy of any extras you'll need at the last minute.
- **Decide who will do what:** For example, perhaps your partner could prepare snacks.
- **Do a trial run** of the trip to the hospital—anticipating areas where there is likely to be traffic, seeking out shortcuts, and figuring out where you are most likely to find a parking space. It can also help to time the run at various points in the day, so you can avoid school-zone hot spots or commuter traffic. Also find out how to get into the maternity unit at night.
- **Above all, don't panic.** The majority of parents-to-be do get to the hospital in plenty of time.

THE BABY'S LENGTH

Whatever their weight, most babies at 40 weeks are approximately the same length— 95 percent are between 17.7 in (45 cm) and 21.6 in (55 cm) long. The length of newborn babies is